

# The Case for Traditional Design Principles in the Built Environment

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Paul Khoury

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## INTRODUCTION

TROY, NY – Though often the object of denigration, almost to the point of cliché, few would deride Troy’s downtown streets as they stroll through its farmer’s market on an Autumn morning. While the food is undoubtedly part of the draw that brings 10,000 people [1] to this fixture of the Capital region every Saturday, it is arguably the atmosphere that plays the greatest role in the success of this tradition. This *atmosphere*, difficult to rigorously quantify, can be understood as a function of and as a product of Troy’s urban fabric, its “good bones”. Much like other beloved historic and architecturally rich neighborhoods across the country – iconic districts such as NYC’s Greenwich Village, Boston’s Beacon Hill, and San Francisco’s Pacific Heights – Troy’s downtown neighborhood was built in an era that predates the primacy of the automobile, of mass production, and of modernism. And it isn’t just the buildings themselves. Many characteristics of these streets, including the capacity and height of the structures, the width of the streets, and the ornamentation on the facades inherently supports a gentle, mixed-use density that naturally catalyzes community and liveliness [2]. Harmony, beauty, and a sense of local character are something that all can agree are positive aspects to possess in a city; why are so few new places capable of emulating this? Why does it almost seem like every development since the ’60s has been a strip mall, a condominium indistinguishable from every other new construction, or an anonymous glass box? Why has a sense of place eroded to the point where, if one were to visit the modern downtown of an unfamiliar city in Asia, the built environment would look almost indiscernible from one in the Americas [3]? This was not always the case. I argue that the commodification of housing and the dominance of global modernist planning have degraded both architecture and urban life.

Reviving traditional design principles such as human-scaled design, aesthetic craftsmanship, and gentle mixed-use density will improve community, affordability, and sustainability.

## BACKGROUND

First, let us begin by briefly defining several key terms: *commodification of housing*, *modernism*, and *traditional architecture*. Commodification of housing refers to the act of treating housing, first and foremost, as a financial instrument or vehicle for wealth-building, as opposed to a human right [4]. If we consider housing a necessity – and therefore a right – the behavior of many real estate investors and the global capital markets in which they operate stand in direct opposition to this principle. The UN Special Rapporteur on Adequate Housing, Leilani Farha, captures this tension succinctly when she explains that treating housing like a globally traded asset fundamentally undermines its social purpose: “I believe there’s a huge difference between housing as a commodity and gold as a commodity. Gold is not a human right; housing is” [5]. Her point is not merely rhetorical; it strikes at the heart of the issue: some things inherently should not be treated like commodities. In some sense, treating a basic human necessity as a plaything of markets is akin to treating people’s lives as a means to an end, violating their rights and their human dignity [6].

Modernism is one of the many forces that co-emerged with, and enabled, the commodification of housing. Broadly speaking, it is a cultural movement borne out of the Industrial Revolution and a desire to reject everything associated with the horrors of the First World War, which ravaged Europe. While nationalist ideology and certain political institutions were largely culpable for breakout the war, tradition, art, and religion were often grouped together with the *ancien régime* and found guilty by association [7]. Modernists called for Europe – and, by extension, the world – to be purged of all that represented the violent past. Reeling from the collective trauma of millions of brutal deaths, many rallied around this cry to renew society. Unfortunately, they saw the world as a zero-sum game in which inherited customs had to be discarded entirely in order to make room for the new. For the scope of this paper, Modernism will be discussed in the context of architecture, where its ideals were embodied in radical new building forms and urban design practices. Any thorough discussion of Modernist architecture would be incomplete without an examination of the Bauhaus movement. The Bauhaus sought to unify art, craft, and industry, celebrating machine production, abstraction, and functionalism; in doing so, it became a driving force behind the clean-lined, ornament-free architecture that would define much of the 20th century. Charles-Édouard Jeanneret, known to the world and to history as Le Corbusier, was perhaps the most important pioneer of modernism. He is quoted saying, “A house is a machine to live in”, a sentiment that fairly captures his philosophy. Simultaneously, on the other side of the Eurasian continent, Mao’s similarly-spirited and similarly-myopic “Destroy the Four Olds” campaign was enthusiastically dismantling heritage and ancestral knowledge, often literally burning it, blind to the unforeseen consequences of such erasure. Traditional architecture and urban design were among the primary targets and greatest casualties of these cultural mass-extinction events.

While many innately associate “traditional architecture” with old-world palaces and cathe-

drals, it extends far beyond that limited view, encompassing vernacular building traditions and the everyday homes of ordinary people. It includes regionally adapted knowledge systems: passive cooling through wind catchers in the Middle East, stepwells in India, steeply pitched roofs in snowy climates, adobe construction in arid regions, and countless other patterns shaped by local climate, culture, and materials. It is intricately linked to the use of local materials available to the inhabitants of a given place. Furthermore, traditional design incorporated culturally significant artforms and ornamentation, refined over generations and passed down from artisan to apprentice or from mother to daughter. These practices not only enhanced the beauty of their communities, enriching daily experience and uplifting inhabitants, but also created a distinctive sense of place.

While the shift of housing from a craft to a commodity was brought about by a cultural tide, it was enabled and sustained by mass production and the standardization of building components. The Industrial Revolution brought forth the capacity to manufacture identical parts at unprecedented scale. Lumber, bricks, windows, and eventually entire prefab structures became fabricable en masse. What was once a necessarily local endeavor became centralized. In becoming consolidated, the building process was divorced from place. This change dramatically reduced the role of skilled artisans; as soon as assembly-line labor and interchangeable parts could substitute for their expertise, their roles were eliminated. The consequences extended far beyond mere aesthetics or even the regrettable shrinkage of the skilled-jobs market; when buildings could be erected quickly and cheaply using standardized components, they became attractive vehicles for financial speculation rather than long-term community investments. This economic transformation from use-value to exchange-value was both cause and consequence of changing legal frameworks. Prior to the mid-20th century, housing was primarily understood as shelter, a place to live and raise a family, with ownership typically held by individuals or small local landlords. However, the post-war period saw the emergence of Real Estate Investment Trusts (REITs) in 1960, which allowed real estate to be traded like stock, and subsequent deregulation that invited increasing amounts of speculative capital into housing markets. The Tax Reform Act of 1986 made real estate investment more attractive to large institutional investors by changing depreciation rules and passive loss limitations. It also consolidated investments into large institutions, pension funds and REITs. More recently, the 2008 financial crisis created an opportunity for private equity firms to purchase distressed properties at scale, transforming single-family homes into rental portfolios managed by distant corporations. Today, when a working family is priced out of their neighborhood, they are not only competing with other families, but with corporations aiming to maximize returns for shareholders who may never set foot in the community they're reshaping. Pattillo keenly observes how "the persistence of homelessness within a context of housing surplus illustrates a resolute deference to the prerogatives and profits of the private housing market".

## SOCIAL & PSYCHOLOGICAL CONSEQUENCES OF MODERNIST DESIGN

The social consequences of modernist planning ideology manifested most dramatically in projects like Le Corbusier's "towers in the park" concept and the sweeping urban renewal

programs of the mid-20th century. These developments, in which high-rise residential buildings were constructed in vast lots were predicated on a fundamental misunderstanding of how communities function. Jane Jacobs, in her widely influential book "The Death and Life of Great American Cities," observed that such projects destroyed the "eyes on the street" – the natural surveillance and social cohesion that emerges from mixed-use neighborhoods where people live, work, and gather throughout the day [8]. When residential towers stand isolated from all the other urban amenities, a diffusion of responsibility occurs; no one feels ownership over the too-large, too-anonymous, too-public expanses. Instead of utopian tranquility, these places became neglected and dangerous spaces. Now that many of these towers in the park developments have stood for more than half a century, they can be judged with historical perspective. Their record is clear: they have, in practice, been largely unsuccessful. The Soviet-era "commie blocks" that still stand throughout Eastern Europe remain stark monuments to this manufactured isolation and alienation. Likewise, the American inner-city "projects" built on the same principles have become some of the most crime-ridden and socially distressed forms of subsidized housing.<sup>1</sup>

Understanding the full impact of these planning mistakes requires looking beyond their physical form and examining their psychological toll, which extends beyond mere inconvenience [9]. Contrast the modernist model with a traditional mixed-use neighborhood. In a more traditional neighborhood, a resident might stop at a corner bakery on their walk to work, chat with neighbors on their stoops, and pass the same faces daily, building the casual social ties that create community resilience and social capital [10]. When we replace walkable streets with highways, or when we mandate parking minimums that push buildings away from sidewalks, or when we outlaw the corner store in residential zones, we are not merely making technical planning decisions, we are dismantling the physical infrastructure that enables human connection. The loneliness epidemic plaguing modern societies is not disconnected from the built environment; it is, in many ways, a direct consequence of planning ideologies that treated human social needs as secondary to abstract modernist principles such as "function" and automobile convenience.

## SUSTAINABILITY FAILURES

In addition to the burden placed on the psychological and social health of communities and their inhabitants, modern construction has a tangible environmental cost. Contemporary concrete and glass construction typically has a functional lifespan of forty to sixty years [11] before requiring major renovation or replacement, which is a shockingly brief duration compared to traditional masonry or brick buildings that often stand for centuries. The primary culprit is rebar corrosion: the steel reinforcement within concrete inevitably rusts as moisture penetrates the structure, causing the rebar to expand and crack the concrete from within, ultimately compromising structural integrity. This obsolescence generates a staggering amount of demolition waste, accounting for roughly 600 million tons of waste in the United States every year [12]. Each demolished building represents not just lost embodied energy, the carbon

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<sup>1</sup> Meanwhile, in the suburbs, zoning that strictly separated homes from shops and workplaces encouraged sprawl and produced communities dependent on cars for nearly every daily action.

emissions from manufacturing and transporting its materials, but also the emissions from constructing its replacement. This creates a vicious cycle of resource extraction, construction, and demolition.<sup>2</sup>

The operational energy inefficiency of modern buildings compounds these lifecycle impacts. Large glass facades, favored by contemporary architects for their minimalist aesthetic, are thermal disasters. Glass conducts heat rapidly, so these buildings lose warmth in winter and gain it in summer, driving an unnecessary reliance on HVAC systems to meet Americans' ever-increasing comfort standards. These sealed glass boxes trap occupants in fully artificial environments, dependent on mechanical systems that consume vast amounts of electricity, often from fossil fuels. Traditional architecture, by contrast, evolved sophisticated passive climate-control strategies over centuries: thick masonry walls that absorb heat during the day and release it at night; high ceilings that allow hot air to rise; courtyards that channel cooling breezes. Even something as simple, obvious, and taken-for-granted as operable windows (that enable natural ventilation instead of air conditioning) are not a feature of glass box buildings. These techniques required no electricity, created no operational emissions, and provided comfortable inside environments, yet we have discarded and, in many cases, forgotten them.

Furthermore, the modern construction industry's reliance on non-local materials dramatically increases embodied carbon while simultaneously eroding regional identity. When every building from Anchorage to Phoenix uses the same mass-produced components, the carbon emissions from transportation are merely the most obvious cost. More insidiously, this globalized supply chain severs the connection between building and place. Traditional architecture inherently expressed its location through materials [14]: the limestone of Paris, the greyed cedar shingles of coastal New England, and the adobe of the Southwestern United States. These materials were not aesthetic choices imposed by architects, but practical responses to what was available locally and what held up. Using local materials meant lower transportation costs and created regional employment. In shipping materials transglobally, we lose these benefits and burn more fossil fuels to transport heavy, low-value commodities across oceans.

## THE INSTITUTIONAL & ECONOMIC DRIVERS OF DECLINE

The transformation of housing from human right to speculative asset has clear beneficiaries and clear architects. According to Pattillo, "The expansion of the market ever further into the spheres of land and housing is an emergent feature of modern capitalism and is neither self-evident nor given." Firms like Blackstone and Invitation Homes (as well as many smaller investors) have purchased hundreds of thousands of homes, converting ownership opportunities into permanent rentals managed by distant corporations and optimized for maximum rent extraction [15]. Foreign investors, particularly from countries with unstable

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<sup>2</sup>Konstantinos A. Doxiadis's discipline of *ekistics* treats cities as energy systems, arguing that every human settlement is shaped and constrained by the movement of energy through and within it. Seen through this lens, modern cities represents not just material waste but a fundamental misalignment with the energy logic that underpins cities [13].

property rights, have “parked” capital in U.S. and European housing markets. This drives up prices while leaving properties vacant as mere stores of value rather than homes. Developers, meanwhile, have discovered that luxury condominiums and corporate housing generate higher profit margins than affordable, human-scaled neighborhoods.

This pattern of degradation follows what technology writer Cory Doctorow terms “enshittification”, which he defines as the process by which “platforms and systems that initially serve users well gradually decay as they prioritize extraction over service” [16]. Doctorow coined this term in his research on tech platforms, but housing markets have followed a very similar trajectory. The cycle is familiar: first, they subsidize users to build market share; then, they abuse users to court business customers; finally, they abuse both users and business customers to maximize profits for shareholders, until the platform becomes so degraded that people would abandon it if possible. Initially, housing was built to serve residents, with developers operating in competitive local markets and constrained by community standards. As markets consolidated, the focus shifted from resident satisfaction to investor returns. This will lead to the maturation of enshittification, where the product is degrading even as the profits are rising. The difference is that unlike leaving a failing tech platform, people cannot easily abandon the housing market because of the reality that they need shelter.

The ideological reinforcement of these design choice, on the other hand, comes from an unexpected source: architectural education itself. Most architecture schools have embraced an exclusively modernist curriculum that treats traditional architecture as antiquated, if they acknowledge it at all. Students are trained to create something avant-garde, to express themselves individualistically, and to be theoretically complex. Ornamentation is dismissed as waste, regional variation as provincial, and human comfort as secondary to conceptual statements<sup>3</sup>. This educational hegemony has consequences: when every graduating architect has been taught that modernist abstraction represents progress and that traditional forms are regression, it is no wonder that the built environment increasingly resembles a collection of competing egos rather than cohesive communities. The result is a professional class that serves its own preoccupations and the profit motives of developer clients, while ordinary people are left to wonder why they find new buildings so antagonizing.

## A PATH TOWARD RESTORATION

The path forward requires returning to human-focused design principles that have proven their worth across centuries and cultures,<sup>4</sup> not through nostalgia but through rigorous attention to how people actually live and thrive. Traditional architecture and urbanism offer profound benefits across multiple domains [18]. They create the physical conditions for community through walkable, mixed-use neighborhoods. They employ passive climate control and durable materials that minimize operational and embodied carbon. Moreover, “aesthetically pleasant spaces promote social interaction, increase the time people spend in pub-

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<sup>3</sup>The University of Notre Dame stands as a notable exception, maintaining a program in Classical Architecture that teaches traditional design principles and hand-drawing skills, but it is an outlier among its peers.

<sup>4</sup>The “Lindy” principle suggests that practices which have endured for centuries tend to be robust. Such practices, institutions, or objects are referred to as “Lindy-proof, that is, hav[ing] an antecedent in the classics.” [17]

lic space, and enhance citizens' perception of security" [2]. These are not separate benefits but interconnected aspects of a holistic approach that treats buildings and neighborhoods as places for human flourishing rather than financial instruments or architectural statements. Research consistently shows that people experience lower stress and greater satisfaction in environments with the characteristics of traditional architecture [19]. A key principle for implementing traditional design in the contemporary world is critical regionalism [14]. This approach respects local climate, culture, and materials while incorporating modern amenities and knowledge. Old-world cities like Paris, Florence, and Kyoto are such beloved tourist destinations because they offer distinctive experiences that generic modernist cities cannot match. American cities that preserved or recreated this character – Charleston's historic district, Savannah's squares, Philadelphia's colonial rowhouses – enjoy similar success in attracting people. People instinctively gravitate toward these environments because they satisfy deep human needs <sup>5</sup>. Critical regionalism does not mean blindly copying historical forms, but rather understanding the principles that made them work.

Across the world, there are encouraging examples of places where traditional principles have been successfully applied to new development. Singapore, despite its reputation as a major global financial hub, actively shields its housing stock <sup>6</sup> from speculation to ensure that homes function primarily as places to live rather than as financial assets [20]. Cayalá, Guatemala is a newer development built according to traditional urbanism principles with human-scaled streets, mixed uses, and regionally appropriate architecture; it has become enormously popular [21]. Poland's reconstruction of historic city centers destroyed during World War II, particularly Warsaw's reconstructed Old Town [22], demonstrates that traditional architecture can be recreated when there is political will and cultural commitment. In the United States, Seaside, Florida, though initially derided as derivative, has proven the viability of New Urbanist principles based on traditional town planning, being so highly desired precisely because it offers what most modern development lacks: genuine public space, architectural coherence, and pedestrian-first streets. These examples demonstrate that traditional design principles remain viable and desirable in the contemporary world.

Critics often raise concerns about cost, claiming that traditional architecture with ornamentation and quality materials is economically unfeasible in today's markets. However, this objection misunderstands both the economics and the comparison. Yes, hand-crafted ornamentation costs more than blank walls, but traditional buildings' longer lifespans (a result of both the material properties and the fact that residents are more inclined to maintain beautiful things) and lower operational costs often make them more economical over time than modern buildings requiring replacement every few decades [23]. Moreover, much of modern construction's supposed cost-efficiency is illusory, achieved by externalizing environmental costs and sacrificing durability for short-term savings. Traditional construction methods can be adapted to contemporary budgets through techniques like prefabricating ornamental ele-

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<sup>5</sup> *Thigmotaxis* is one of these instincts and refers to the innate animal tendency to seek physical or spatial contact with boundaries such as walls as a source of comfort and security. In urban design, this principle helps explain why people prefer streets that are not overly wide and why arcades, alcoves, and other enclosures are beloved by many.

<sup>6</sup> In addition to other limitations, the Singaporean government enforces that certain homes to be sold on a 99-year lease, which helps stabilize long-term value and discourages investment speculation.

ments [24] or using modern materials that mimic traditional ones where appropriate. When we account for demolished buildings' embodied energy, the health costs of alienating environments, the infrastructure expenses of car-dependent sprawl, and the social costs of isolated communities, traditional architecture and urbanism is not merely aesthetically preferable but economically and environmentally superior.

## CONCLUSION

An old anecdote<sup>7</sup> holds that if you encounter a fence and don't know why it was placed there, you should not remove it until you understand its original purpose. Traditional architecture operates in much the same way. The knowledge embodied in traditional design principles was hard-won over many generations. While the rationale may not be immediately obvious to the modern observer, that does not mean it is useless. The question is not whether these methods are old, but whether they work, and for centuries, they have. Recognizing the enduring value of these practices is not an exercise in nostalgia; it is an argument for a built environment that serves the people who inhabit it. By relearning what past generations discovered, we gain tools to create thriving communities. However, relearning what past generations discovered is only the first step. The deeper challenge is determining how these insights can be translated into practical policy and pedagogical decisions. How might zoning laws be best rewritten to give rise to walkable, mixed-use neighborhoods; what financial structures would make human-scaled buildings economically viable again; how might we change attitudes to take human psychology, environmental concerns, and cultural heritage more seriously? And perhaps most importantly: what could our cities achieve if we designed them around people rather than around capital or abstract dogmas? By confronting these questions, we begin to walk toward a more positive future where urban environments are more beautiful and enduring.

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<sup>7</sup>Often referred to as Chesterton's Fence, introduced by the writer G. K. Chesterton in his 1929 book *The Thing*. A modern example of a Chesterton's fence is the mysterious line of code that seems unnecessary until its deletion breaks the entire program.



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